called a “domestic brain drain.”[10] Highly trained workers left skilled positions in the state sector for unskilled work that paid more. Education itself became less important. The government could no longer guarantee employment, even to young people who graduated with fine credentials. Before the 1990s, almost everybody who graduated received a job placement with their diploma. In 2001, only 72 percent did.[11]

Another disincentive was that professional jobs were no longer a guarantee of material security. Like the brain surgeon in the joke, many educated Cubans abandoned or supplemented their professions and went to work for dollars. Government restrictions tried to limit the drain by prohibiting certain groups of professionals – like doctors – from working in the private economy. But this policy, in turn, discouraged many ambitious young people from seeking education. Higher education was supposed to lead to greater opportunity – now it looked like more education was going to limit a young person’s opportunity. Opportunities for higher education also shrank, as university slots were reduced to accommodate the lack of available jobs for college graduates. In 1980, 17 percent of the school-age population had gone on to pursue higher education, while in 1990, the figure was 21 percent. In 1997, only 12 percent did. “One of Latin America’s most educated populations became ‘deschooled’ as well as ‘deskilled’,” Susan Eckstein concluded. Several thousand school-age children (ages 5–11) “worked” in the old section of Havana, either begging or offering minor goods and services to tourists.[12]

The money that Miami Cubans sent to their relatives on the island created other contradictions. Overall, Miami Cubans came from the wealthier, and whiter, sectors of pre-revolutionary Cuban society. Although the Miami Cuban community had diversified since the Mariel boat lift in 1980, the earlier, whiter arrivals were still economically better off. They also tended to be more politically anti-revolutionary. Their relatives in Cuba, who had long tried to downplay any connection to the former elites and the Miami exile community, suddenly found that these old relationships were an advantage instead of a disadvantage.